

Household Hazardous Waste

Your guide to transfer station handling of household hazardous waste (HHW).

What is Household Hazardous Waste?

Household hazardous waste (HHW) includes chemical products commonly used in homes and communities that may contain ingredients that are harmful to both people and the environment. These materials remain hazardous when they are discarded, and they exhibit characteristics of toxicity, flammability, corrosivity, and/or reactivity as shown below.

Transfer stations may collect HHW generated from cleaning, household projects, garden equipment, pest control, vehicle maintenance, and hobbies. Additionally, HHW collection facilities may be used by certain small businesses, like neighborhood mechanics, community gardeners, painting contractors, schools, casinos, and gas stations.

Common examples of HHW:

- Used oil and oil filters
- Paints
- Solvents
- Electronic waste
- Batteries
- Fluorescent lamps
- Automotive products
- Garden chemicals
- Cleaning products
- Pesticides

			
Toxic	Flammable	Corrosive	Reactive
Listed by EPA, health-based concentration limits	Federal flash point below 140 °F	pH ≤ 2.0 or ≥ 12.5	Violent change without detonating, water reactive
	Oxidizers		

Characteristics of Hazardous Waste & Classification

Classifying and Sorting HHW

Check any labels that may contain information on ingredients, signal words, and symbols, or other helpful data. Consider the use of the material and the type of container it is in.

Once HHW is classified, segregate the wastes according to the hazard type as follows:

- ✓ Store **flammables** separately from other chemicals, ideally in a flammable storage cabinet.
- ✓ Separate **corrosive acids** and **corrosive bases** from each other.

- ✓ Store **oxidizers** separately from all other chemicals, and separate them by chemical ingredient; for example, separate pool chemicals with hypochlorites from fertilizers like nitrates.
- ✓ Separate **reactives** from all other chemicals and from each other to avoid adverse reactions. Examples include ammunition, water reactives, and cyanide wastes.

Initial HHW Collection Best Practices

Waste Acceptance

- ✓ Educate the public about proper management of HHW.
- ✓ Establish a list of what HHW is acceptable and what HHW the transfer station does not accept.
- ✓ To counteract illegal dumping, identify alternative disposal options for unacceptable HHW.

Receiving

- ✓ Screen incoming material to identify unknown wastes and check for unsafe containers or leaks.
- ✓ Establish drop-off procedures – either a staffed drop-off or unstaffed, self-drop-off areas.
- ✓ Sort and distribute HHW to proper hazard class storage.

Sorting

- ✓ Place sorted HHW into containers or on shelves in labeled leak-proof tubs.
- ✓ Isolate unknown chemicals until they are identified.
- ✓ Separate incompatibles to avoid potential reactions between HHW.
- ✓ Store sorted HHW off the ground and in a covered area.
- ✓ Place liquids in secondary containment to contain spillage.

HHW Storage and Management Best Practices

Storage Area Elements & Features

- ✓ Confirm presence of or access to the following:
 - Signage and safety warnings
 - Lockers and other secure storage
 - Storage for supplies, such as shelves, garbage cans, and cardboard boxes
 - Drum dolly or forklift access
 - Sufficient lighting
 - Fire suppression
 - Secondary containment for liquids
 - Both high- and low-ventilation storage areas

Storage Area Guidelines

- ✓ Label containers with the hazard class and the date of initial accumulation.
- ✓ Keep containers closed at all times.
- ✓ Regularly inspect containers for deterioration and, if needed, transfer a damaged container and its contents into a new, secure container or bag.
- ✓ Keep adequate aisle space to allow space and visibility to check container condition.
- ✓ Do not allow products to spill or mix together.
- ✓ Keep containers off the ground, but at or below eye level.
- ✓ Prevent uncontrolled stockpiling of wastes.
- ✓ Use plastic tubs to separate incompatibles and unknowns.
- ✓ Bag individual containers in clear plastic as needed for safety.

Training Requirements

Transfer station operators accepting HHW need specialized training, such as Hazardous Waste Operations and Emergency Response (HAZWOPER), to confirm their station's operations are safe and compliant. HHW must be handled directly by transfer station operators or contractors specifically trained to manage such waste.

State Requirements

The Environmental Protection Agency (EPA) does not regulate HHW as hazardous waste and a unique EPA identification number, or Resource Conservation and Recovery (RCRA) ID, is not required. However, your hazardous waste contractor may require a RCRA ID number, and some states have additional HHW requirements – for example, states may impose regulatory limits on how long certain types of HHW may be accumulated. Tribes must abide by applicable state laws for wastes transported to a collection facility off Tribal lands. Contact your state's environmental agency for guidance.

Additional Resources:

[EPA's webpage for Household Hazardous Waste \(HHW\)](#) has information on safe management and reduction of HHW, as well as additional information for state and community programs.

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